# South Island Self-Drive: Christchurch to Queenstown

**6-14 March 2027 · 2 adults · 1 driver · 8 nights · one-way rental car CHC to ZQN**

Prepared 9 November 2026. Nothing has been booked. Every booking listed in this plan is still for you to make.

## 1. The plan in one paragraph

Fly into Christchurch on Saturday afternoon and stay at the airport Novotel. Next day, cross the Southern Alps on Arthur's Pass to the West Coast glaciers (2 nights in Franz Josef). Then drive the Haast Pass to Wanaka, go inland via the Lindis Pass to Lake Pukaki, Aoraki/Mount Cook and Lake Tekapo, and come back over the Lindis to Queenstown. From Queenstown, do the Milford Road by car with no cruise and sleep in Te Anau, then finish with a last night in Queenstown. Total driving is about **2,198 km** and **37 h 10 min** at the wheel, including a 10% buffer. The longest day is Day 2 at 445 km, under your 500 km limit. Every drive ends at least 1 hour before sunset. There are no boats, no beach walks, and no walk longer than about 1 hr 40 min including stops. 4 of the 8 nights are Accor hotels (Christchurch, Tekapo, Queenstown x2). The West Coast, Wanaka and Te Anau have no Accor hotel.

## 2. Trip at a glance

| Day | Date | Route | km | Drive (planned) | Last arrival | Sunset | Overnight |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Sat 6 Mar | Arrive Christchurch: kiwi, kea and the Port Hills lookouts | 52 | 1h35 | 19:00 | 20:08 | Christchurch Airport |
| 2 | Sun 7 Mar | Over Arthur's Pass to the glaciers | 445 | 7h00 | 18:15 | 20:16 | Franz Josef / Waiau |
| 3 | Mon 8 Mar | Glacier day: Franz Josef, Okarito lookout, kiwi, Lake Matheson | 121 | 2h40 | 19:00 | 20:14 | Franz Josef / Waiau (2nd night) |
| 4 | Tue 9 Mar | Haast Pass: seals, waterfalls and the Blue Pools to Wanaka | 285 | 4h30 | 15:40 | 20:17 | Wanaka |
| 5 | Wed 10 Mar | Lindis Pass, Lake Pukaki and Aoraki/Mount Cook to Lake Tekapo | 330 | 5h15 | 16:40 | 20:10 | Lake Tekapo |
| 6 | Thu 11 Mar | Mt John lookout, Lindis Pass, Kawarau Gorge and Arrowtown to Queenstown | 281 | 5h05 | 17:55 | 20:16 | Queenstown |
| 7 | Fri 12 Mar | Milford Road by car (no cruise): Mirror Lakes, Homer Tunnel, the Chasm | 410 | 6h40 | 17:30 | 20:16 | Te Anau |
| 8 | Sat 13 Mar | Back to Queenstown: Kiwi Park and the Glenorchy Road lookouts | 265 | 4h10 | 16:10 | 20:12 | Queenstown |
| 9 | Sun 14 Mar | Return the car and fly (no sightseeing) | 9 | 15 min | 08:15 | 20:10 | - |
| | | **Total** | **2,198** | **37h10** | | | |

Planned drive time is the OSRM road-network time plus 10% (the buffer this method uses), rounded up to 5 minutes. Last arrival is when the final drive of the day ends. Sunset times are calculated for the overnight town, in NZDT (UTC+13; daylight saving runs until 4 April 2027).

## 3. How the plan meets your requirements

| Your requirement | How the plan handles it | Status |
|---|---|---|
| One-way Christchurch (CHC) to Queenstown (ZQN); land Sat 6 Mar 14:30, fly Sun 14 Mar 11:00 | Car out at CHC about 15:45 on 6 Mar; car back at ZQN by 08:30 on 14 Mar | Met |
| At most 500 km per day | Longest day 445 km (Day 2). Day 7 Milford is 410 km. Every other day is under 340 km. | Met |
| Never drive after dark | Every day's last drive ends at least 1 h 08 min before sunset. The earliest departure (07:15 on Day 2) is at sunrise. Evening activities (Skyline, Wanaka Tree, Tekapo church, stargazing tour) are on foot or use operator transport. | Met |
| One driver | Breaks at least every 2 hr. The two long days (445 and 410 km) are not back to back, and a short 121 km day follows the long one. | Met |
| See as much as possible; early starts fine | Departures from 07:15-07:45 on most driving days. 43 timed stops. | Met |
| Interests: mountains and lookouts, lakes, glaciers, wildlife | Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass, Lindis Pass, Mt Cook, Milford Road, Mt John, Okarito Trig and Mt Iron. Lakes: Matheson, Wanaka, Hawea, Pukaki, Tekapo, Wakatipu, Gunn, Mirror Lakes. Glaciers: Franz Josef, Fox (from Lake Matheson), Tasman. Wildlife: kiwi (3 places), kea, takahē, fur seals, tuatara. | Met |
| No boats or ferries | No Milford/Doubtful Sound cruise, no Te Anau glowworm caves (boat access), no Kaikōura whale watching. Milford Sound is seen from the shore. | Met |
| No beaches | Ship Creek, Monro Beach, Gillespies Beach and the Okarito beach walk are left out. Knights Point is a clifftop lookout. | Met |

| Your requirement | How the plan handles it | Status |
|---|---|---|
| No walks longer than about 2 hr | The longest walks are about 1.5 hr: Okarito Trig, Lake Matheson and Mt Iron. Hooker Valley (3 hr), Roys Peak and Key Summit are excluded. | Met |
| Accor as many nights as possible; two beds; up to NZ$300 | 4 of 8 nights are Accor (the maximum on this route: there are no Accor hotels on the West Coast, in Wanaka or in Te Anau). Request a twin or 2-queen room. Queenstown in March may cost more than NZ$300 (see section 8). | Partly: Queenstown rate needs checking |
| 14 Mar: no sightseeing | Hotel to the airport only (9 km). | Met |
| Only flights booked; PDF in English | Booking list with book-by dates is in section 9 | Met |

## 4. Assumptions (things you did not specify)

- Your flight into Christchurch is international (from Australia), so allow about 60 minutes from landing to driving away. Your 11:00 flight out of Queenstown is treated as international too, so the car is back about 2.5 hr before departure.
- Rental car: an ordinary 2WD car, not a campervan, picked up at the Christchurch Airport terminal and dropped at the Queenstown Airport terminal. One-way fees apply. Fuel is full-to-full. You drive only on sealed roads (most rental contracts exclude unsealed roads).
- Your full Australian licence in English is valid in New Zealand for up to 12 months. Carry the physical card.
- Hotel prices are your budget per room per night (NZ$300), using Accor member rates where possible. I could not see live March 2027 prices, so each one has to be checked when you book.
- Walking pace is average. Walk times are DOC figures where available. Dwell times include parking and toilets.
- Weather: early March is late summer, usually 15-25°C inland and wetter on the West Coast. Each day has a plan B.

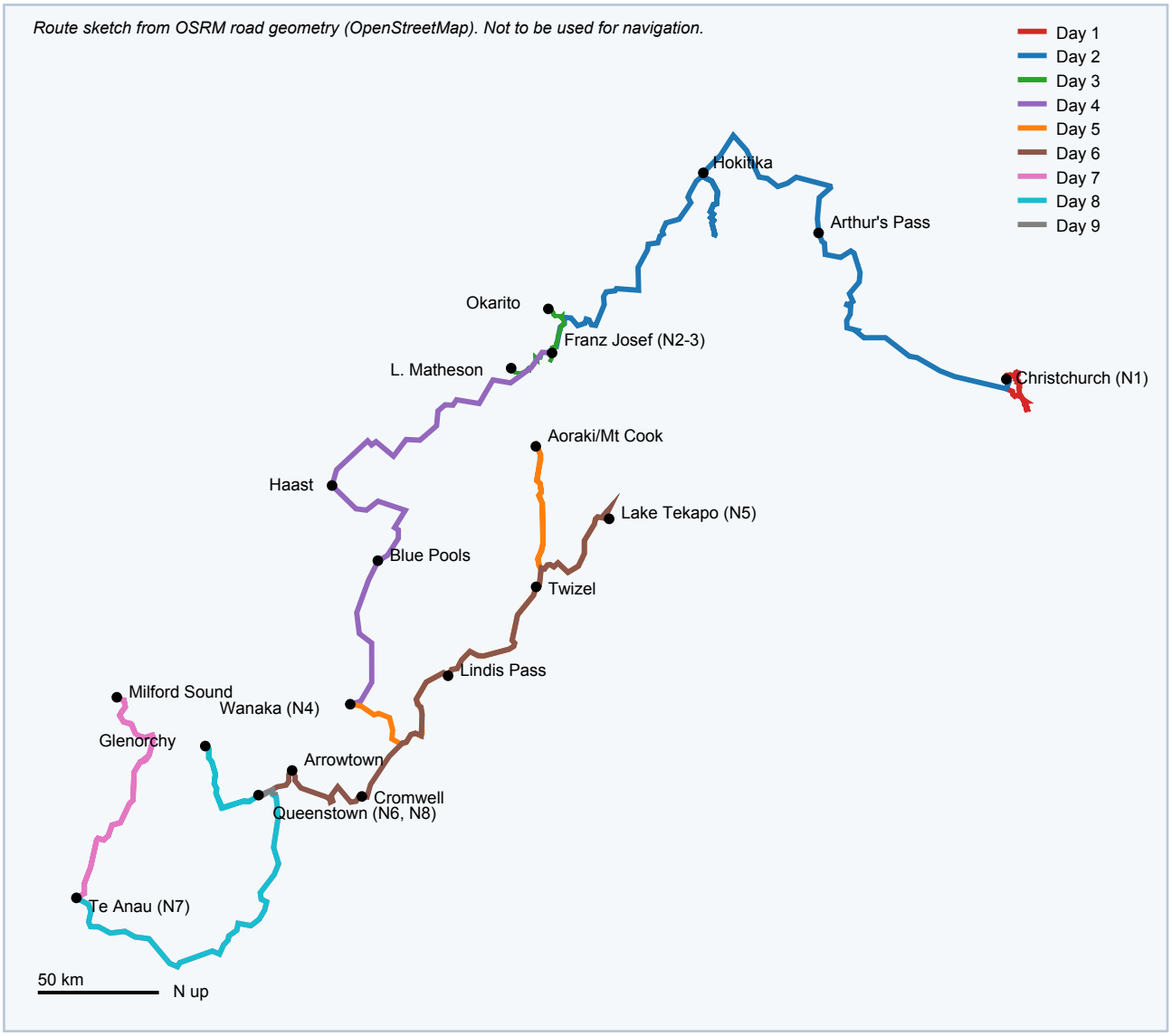
## 5. Choosing the route order (optimisation step)

The visit order was fixed by geography (a one-way trip from Christchurch to Queenstown with the stops grouped by region). I compared the four ways of joining the regions using OSRM driving distances along the main road skeleton, without side trips:

| Option | Order | Skeleton km | Verdict |
|---|---|---|---|
| A (chosen) | CHC - Arthur's Pass - West Coast glaciers - Haast Pass - Wanaka - Mt Cook - Tekapo - Queenstown - Te Anau/Milford - Queenstown | 1,808 | Covers every interest. The only repeated road is about 125 km of Twizel-Lindis Pass. Includes Arthur's Pass (mountains, kea). |
| B | CHC - Tekapo - Mt Cook - Wanaka - Haast Pass - glaciers - back over Haast Pass - Queenstown - Te Anau/Milford - Queenstown | 1,753 | 55 km shorter, but it drives the Haast Pass twice (about 280 km repeated) and misses Arthur's Pass. |
| C | CHC - Tekapo - Mt Cook - Wanaka - Queenstown - Te Anau/Milford - Queenstown | 1,183 | Too short for 8 nights; no West Coast glaciers (the Tasman Glacier only). |
| D | As A but without Mt Cook and Tekapo | 1,310 | Leaves out Aoraki/Mt Cook and the Mackenzie lakes, which are central to 'mountains and lakes'. |

Within each day, stops are ordered along the road so that there is no backtracking (the nearest-neighbour order along a linear corridor). The only exceptions are Day 3's out-and-back trips from the Franz Josef base and Day 8's Glenorchy spur.

## 6. Route map


Route sketch from OSRM road geometry (OpenStreetMap). Not to be used for navigation.
Day 1
Day 2
Day 3
Day 4
Day 5
Day 6
Day 7
Day 8
Day 9
Hokitika
Arthur's Pass
Okarito
Franz Josef (N2-3)
L. Matheson
Christchurch (N1)
Aoraki/Mt Cook
Haast
Lake Tekapo (N5)
Blue Pools
Twizel
Lindis Pass
Milford Sound
Wanaka (N4)
Glenorchy
Arrowtown
Cromwell
Queenstown (N6, N8)
Te Anau (N7)
50 km
N up

# 7. Day-by-day itinerary

Times assume the start time shown. 'Drive' rows use the planned time (OSRM time + 10%). Time at each stop is planned; shorten it if you are running late. You do not have to arrive exactly on time; the important figure is how much daylight is left at the end of the day.

## Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar 2027 · Arrive Christchurch: kiwi, kea and the Port Hills lookouts

**Start** 15:45 from Christchurch Airport (rental car park) · **Overnight** Christchurch Airport · **Distance** 52 km · **Driving** 1h35 planned (OSRM 1h16) · **Sunrise** 07:14 · **Sunset** 20:08 · **Last drive ends** 19:00 (1h08 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 15:45 | 16:05 | Drive | *Drive to Willowbank Wildlife Reserve* | 10 km | 20 min | 60 Hussey Rd, Northwood |
| 16:05 | 17:05 | Stop | **Willowbank Wildlife Reserve** | | 1h00 | Kiwi in the nocturnal house, kea, other native birds. Usual hours 9:30-17:00 daily; confirm last entry (tel +64 3 359 6226). Paid entry. |
| 17:05 | 17:45 | Drive | *Drive to Sign of the Kiwi, Summit Road (Port Hills)* | 21 km | 40 min | Via Dyers Pass Rd; winding hill road |
| 17:45 | 18:25 | Stop | **Port Hills Summit Road lookouts** | | 40 min | Free roadside lookouts over Lyttelton Harbour, the Canterbury Plains and the Southern Alps; short strolls only. |
| 18:25 | 19:00 | Drive | *Drive to Novotel Christchurch Airport* | 21 km | 35 min | Check in; dinner at the hotel or the airport area |

- Landing 14:30. Allow about 60 min for immigration, biosecurity and the rental desk, so the plan assumes the car is out at about 15:45.
- If the flight or rental desk runs late, drop Willowbank (it closes at 17:00) and go straight to the Port Hills, or rest. You still need to be parked by about 19:40.
- Buy water and snacks for tomorrow's long mountain day. Arthur's Pass village has only a small store and cafe.

**Plan B:** Rain or low cloud: skip the Port Hills and stay longer at Willowbank (wildlife is indoors or under cover).

## Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar 2027 · Over Arthur's Pass to the glaciers

**Start** 07:15 from Novotel Christchurch Airport · **Overnight** Franz Josef / Waiau · **Distance** 445 km · **Driving** 7h00 planned (OSRM 6h11) · **Sunrise** 07:25 · **Sunset** 20:16 · **Last drive ends** 18:15 (2h01 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 07:15 | 08:45 | Drive | *Drive to Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill* | 93 km | 1h30 | SH73 via Springfield (last cheap fuel before the pass is in Springfield or Christchurch) |
| 08:45 | 09:30 | Stop | **Castle Hill limestone boulders** | | 45 min | Easy 30-45 min wander among the boulders; mountain views. |
| 09:30 | 10:25 | Drive | *Drive to Arthur's Pass village (Devils Punchbowl car park)* | 53 km | 55 min | Alpine road; pass Lake Pearson and the Waimakariri River flats |
| 10:25 | 11:40 | Stop | **Devils Punchbowl Falls walk + village** | | 1h15 | About 1 hr return; steep, 400+ steps to a viewing platform below a 131 m waterfall. Look for kea (alpine parrots) around the village. Do not feed them and do not leave the car unattended with food. Coffee/toilets in the village. |
| 11:40 | 11:50 | Drive | *Drive to Otira Viaduct Lookout* | 6 km | 10 min | Steep descent on the west side; low gear |
| 11:50 | 12:05 | Stop | **Otira Viaduct Lookout** | | 15 min | Classic lookout over the viaduct and the gorge; kea often visit. |
| 12:05 | 13:30 | Drive | *Drive to Hokitika* | 94 km | 1h25 | SH73 then SH6 south at Kumara Junction |
| 13:30 | 14:15 | Stop | **Hokitika: lunch + FUEL** | | 45 min | Fill the tank here (several stations in town per OpenStreetMap: BP, Challenge, NPD). |
| 14:15 | 14:50 | Drive | *Drive to Hokitika Gorge* | 34 km | 35 min | Inland via Kaniere/Kokatahi; sealed |
| 14:50 | 15:50 | Stop | **Hokitika Gorge walk** | | 1h00 | Turquoise glacial river, swing bridge, lookout; about 1 hr including the viewpoint loop. |
| 15:50 | 18:15 | Drive | *Drive to Franz Josef / Waiau* | 165 km | 2h25 | Back roads to SH6, then south via Ross and Harihari (fuel also in Ross) |

- This is the longest day: 445 km. It is still under your 500 km limit, and you arrive with more than two hours of daylight left.
- Lighter option: skip Hokitika Gorge. That makes the day 379 km with about 1h30 less driving and walking.
- Single driver: take a 15-20 min break at every stop listed. Never drive the West Coast road tired.

**Plan B:** If SH73 is closed (check NZTA Journey Planner the night before), the only alternative is SH7 Lewis Pass. Christchurch to Franz Josef that way is more than 500 km, so you would sleep in Hokitika and continue the next morning. Day 3 would then be shorter.

## Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar 2027 · Glacier day: Franz Josef, Okarito lookout, kiwi, Lake Matheson

**Start** 08:00 from Franz Josef hotel · **Overnight** Franz Josef / Waiau (2nd night) · **Distance** 121 km · **Driving** 2h40 planned (OSRM 2h11) · **Sunrise** 07:26 · **Sunset** 20:14 · **Last drive ends** 19:00 (1h14 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 08:00 | 08:10 | Drive | *Drive to Franz Josef Glacier car park* | 4 km | 10 min | Glacier Access Road, end of road |

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 08:10 | 09:55 | Stop | **Franz Josef Glacier / Ka Roimata o Hine Hukatere valley walk + Sentinel Rock + Peters Pool** | | 1h45 | Valley walk to the glacier viewpoint (river erosion now limits how far up the valley you can go), plus two 20-min side walks. All flat and well under 2 hr. DOC ran a parking-fee pilot here to June 2026, so take a card in case fees continue. |
| 09:55 | 10:35 | Drive | *Drive to Okarito (passing Lake Mapourika)* | 32 km | 40 min | Quick photo stop at Lake Mapourika on the way |
| 10:35 | 12:15 | Stop | **Okarito Trig walk** | | 1h40 | About 1.5 hr return through forest to a lookout over Okarito Lagoon and the Southern Alps (Aoraki/Mt Cook on a clear day). Stay on the trig track, not the coastal beach route. |
| 12:15 | 12:45 | Drive | *Drive to Franz Josef / Waiau* | 28 km | 30 min | |
| 12:45 | 13:45 | Stop | **Lunch in Franz Josef** | | 1h00 | |
| 13:45 | 15:00 | Stop | **West Coast Wildlife Centre (walk from hotel)** | | 1h15 | Rowi and Haast tokoeka kiwi (two of the world's rarest kiwi) in the nocturnal house, plus tuatara. Usual hours about 8:30-18:00; confirm. |
| 15:00 | 16:00 | Stop | **Free slot: optional helicopter glacier flight** | | 1h00 | OPTIONAL and weather-dependent: a helicopter flight with a snow landing on the glacier (no boat involved). Note that it can also cause motion sickness. Book a day ahead or on the morning itself, depending on the weather. If you skip it, rest or revisit the glacier viewpoints. |
| 16:00 | 16:40 | Drive | *Drive to Lake Matheson car park (near Fox Glacier township)* | 29 km | 40 min | SH6 south, then Cook Flat Rd |
| 16:40 | 18:20 | Stop | **Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati circuit** | | 1h40 | 1 hr 30 min, 4.4 km loop (DOC). Mirror reflections of Aoraki/Mt Cook and Mt Tasman from the View of Views. Evenings are often calm. Sandflies: bring repellent. |
| 18:20 | 19:00 | Drive | *Drive to Franz Josef / Waiau* | 28 km | 40 min | Back over the hill road; well before sunset |

- Fox Glacier: the old valley access road has been closed since 2019, so this plan views the Fox side from Lake Matheson instead.
- If the evening at Lake Matheson is cloudy, do it on Day 4 morning instead. It is only a 12 km detour on the way south.

**Plan B:** Heavy rain is common on the West Coast. If the valley walk closes for flooding, spend longer at the Wildlife Centre and the Glacier Hot Pools in town, and move Okarito or Lake Matheson to the drier window.

## Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar 2027 · Haast Pass: seals, waterfalls and the Blue Pools to Wanaka

**Start** 07:45 from Franz Josef hotel · **Overnight** Wanaka · **Distance** 285 km · **Driving** 4h30 planned (OSRM 3h45) · **Sunrise** 07:31 · **Sunset** 20:17 · **Last drive ends** 15:40 (4h37 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 07:45 | 09:35 | Drive | *Drive to Knights Point Lookout* | 116 km | 1h50 | SH6 via Fox Glacier (fuel) and Bruce Bay |
| 09:35 | 09:50 | Stop | **Knights Point Lookout** | | 15 min | Clifftop lookout; NZ fur seals are often visible on the rocks below (bring binoculars). Lookout only, no beach access needed. |
| 09:50 | 10:15 | Drive | *Drive to Haast* | 28 km | 25 min | |
| 10:15 | 10:45 | Stop | **Haast: FUEL + DOC visitor centre** | | 30 min | Fuel at Haast (Johnston Motors per OSM). Next fuel is Makarora, 80 km away. |
| 10:45 | 11:30 | Drive | *Drive to Thunder Creek Falls* | 50 km | 45 min | SH6 climbs the Haast River valley; one-lane bridges |
| 11:30 | 11:45 | Stop | **Thunder Creek Falls** | | 15 min | 5 min each way to a 28 m waterfall. |
| 11:45 | 11:50 | Drive | *Drive to Fantail Falls* | 6 km | 5 min | |
| 11:50 | 12:00 | Stop | **Fantail Falls** | | 10 min | 2 min to the river flats; cairn field. |
| 12:00 | 12:15 | Drive | *Drive to Blue Pools car park* | 14 km | 15 min | Over the Haast Pass summit (563 m); Gates of Haast bridge en route |
| 12:15 | 13:25 | Stop | **Blue Pools walk** | | 1h10 | About 30 min each way through beech forest to swing bridges over glacier-blue pools (DOC). Trout are often visible. |
| 13:25 | 13:35 | Drive | *Drive to Makarora* | 9 km | 10 min | |
| 13:35 | 14:20 | Stop | **Makarora: lunch + optional fuel** | | 45 min | |
| 14:20 | 14:50 | Drive | *Drive to The Neck lookout (between Lakes Wanaka and Hawea)* | 32 km | 30 min | Estimated split of the OSRM Makarora-Wanaka leg |
| 14:50 | 15:10 | Stop | **The Neck + Lake Hawea lookouts** | | 20 min | Two roadside lookouts across both lakes. |
| 15:10 | 15:40 | Drive | *Drive to Wanaka* | 31 km | 30 min | Check in |

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 15:40 | 17:20 | Stop | **Mt Iron walk (3 km drive from town)** | | 1h40 | About 1.5 hr loop to a summit lookout over Lake Wanaka, Lake Hawea and the Clutha. After that, walk (no driving) to That Wanaka Tree for sunset at about 20:15. |

- Phone coverage is patchy or absent between Fox Glacier and Makarora. Download offline maps the night before.
- Ship Creek and Monro Beach are skipped on purpose (both are beach walks).

**Plan B:** SH6 Haast Pass can close at short notice for slips or flooding. Check NZTA Journey Planner before leaving. If it is closed, stay another night in Franz Josef or Haast and wait. The detour via Arthur's Pass and Christchurch is far more than 500 km.

## Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar 2027 · Lindis Pass, Lake Pukaki and Aoraki/Mount Cook to Lake Tekapo

**Start** 07:45 from Wanaka hotel · **Overnight** Lake Tekapo · **Distance** 330 km · **Driving** 5h15 planned (OSRM 4h38) · **Sunrise** 07:27 · **Sunset** 20:10 · **Last drive ends** 16:40 (3h30 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 07:45 | 08:55 | Drive | *Drive to Lindis Pass summit lookout* | 80 km | 1h10 | SH6 to Tarras, SH8 over the pass |
| 08:55 | 09:05 | Stop | **Lindis Pass lookout** | | 10 min | Tussock-covered mountain pass, 971 m. |
| 09:05 | 10:00 | Drive | *Drive to Twizel* | 63 km | 55 min | Via Omarama |
| 10:00 | 10:25 | Stop | **Twizel: FUEL + coffee** | | 25 min | Fill up here. Mt Cook Village has only limited fuel. |
| 10:25 | 10:45 | Drive | *Drive to Peters Lookout (Lake Pukaki)* | 21 km | 20 min | SH8 then SH80 |
| 10:45 | 11:00 | Stop | **Peters Lookout** | | 15 min | The classic view of turquoise Lake Pukaki with Aoraki/Mt Cook behind. |
| 11:00 | 11:50 | Drive | *Drive to Tasman Valley car park** | 48 km | 50 min | *Estimated: OSRM 39.8 km to the Tasman Valley Rd turn plus about 8 km to the car park |
| 11:50 | 12:40 | Stop | **Tasman Glacier View + Blue Lakes** | | 50 min | About 15 min climb each way to the Tasman Glacier and lake viewpoint, plus a 5-min side trip to the Blue Lakes (DOC). The car park fills in summer. |
| 12:40 | 13:00 | Drive | *Drive to White Horse Hill car park* | 10 km | 20 min | |
| 13:00 | 14:10 | Stop | **Kea Point walk** | | 1h10 | 1 hr return from the White Horse Hill car park (DOC) to a deck facing Mt Sefton, the Mueller Glacier lake and Aoraki/Mt Cook. |
| 14:10 | 14:15 | Drive | *Drive to Aoraki/Mount Cook Village* | 2 km | 5 min | |
| 14:15 | 15:05 | Stop | **Lunch + Sir Edmund Hillary Alpine Centre (optional)** | | 50 min | Hooker Valley Track: the full walk is about 3 hr, longer than your 2-hr limit, and the upper section has been closed while a new bridge is built. Walking to the first swing bridge and back is an optional extra of about 1 hr, if DOC shows it open. |
| 15:05 | 16:40 | Drive | *Drive to Lake Tekapo (Peppers Bluewater Resort)* | 105 km | 1h35 | Back along Lake Pukaki; SH8 to Tekapo |

- Evening, on foot: the Church of the Good Shepherd and the sheepdog statue on the lakeshore, about 1 km from the hotel.
- OPTIONAL: Tekapo is in the Aoraki Mackenzie International Dark Sky Reserve. A guided night stargazing tour (for example the Dark Sky Project) uses the operator's own transport, so it does not break your no-night-driving rule. It is dark enough from about 21:30.

**Plan B:** If Aoraki is hidden in cloud, swap: drive Wanaka to Tekapo directly via Lake Pukaki, then visit Mount Cook on Day 6 morning on the way out. On Day 6 that means Tekapo to Mt Cook Village (105 km), then Mt Cook to Twizel and on to Queenstown, about 365 km in total, which is still within your limit.

## Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar 2027 · Mt John lookout, Lindis Pass, Kawarau Gorge and Arrowtown to Queenstown

**Start** 09:50 from Peppers Bluewater, Lake Tekapo · **Overnight** Queenstown · **Distance** 281 km · **Driving** 5h05 planned (OSRM 4h25) · **Sunrise** 07:35 · **Sunset** 20:16 · **Last drive ends** 17:55 (2h21 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 09:50 | 10:20 | Drive | *Drive to Mt John summit (toll road)* | 9 km | 30 min | Private road; reported 2026 hours 10:00-16:00, about NZ$14 per car, paid at the gate (confirm) |
| 10:20 | 11:05 | Stop | **Mt John summit + Astro Cafe** | | 45 min | 360-degree lookout over Lake Tekapo, Lake Alexandrina and the Mackenzie Basin. |
| 11:05 | 12:20 | Drive | *Drive to Twizel* | 63 km | 1h15 | |
| 12:20 | 13:05 | Stop | **Lunch in Twizel** | | 45 min | |
| 13:05 | 14:00 | Drive | *Drive to Lindis Pass* | 63 km | 55 min | Same road as yesterday in reverse (unavoidable) |
| 14:00 | 14:05 | Stop | **Lindis Pass (short stretch)** | | 5 min | |
| 14:05 | 15:10 | Drive | *Drive to Cromwell* | 77 km | 1h05 | SH8 via Tarras |
| 15:10 | 15:35 | Stop | **Cromwell: fruit stalls / old town** | | 25 min | FUEL here or in Queenstown. |
| 15:35 | 15:50 | Drive | *Drive to Roaring Meg lookout (Kawarau Gorge)* | 15 km | 15 min | |

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 15:50 | 16:00 | Stop | **Roaring Meg lookout** | | 10 min | |
| 16:00 | 16:35 | Drive | *Drive to Arrowtown (passing the Kawarau Gorge bridge)* | 32 km | 35 min | Optional 10-min stop at the Kawarau bridge viewing deck (watching only) |
| 16:35 | 17:25 | Stop | **Arrowtown** | | 50 min | Gold-rush main street and the Chinese settlement walk (about 20 min). |
| 17:25 | 17:55 | Drive | *Drive to Queenstown (Novotel Queenstown Lakeside)* | 20 km | 30 min | Check in, then park the car for the evening |

- Before leaving Tekapo (on foot, no car): a sunrise walk along the lakeshore at about 07:30, then breakfast and check-out.
- Evening in Queenstown, on foot: take the Skyline Gondola (base about 10 min walk from the hotel) up Bob's Peak for the sunset view over Lake Wakatipu and the Remarkables. Sunset is about 20:15; ride down and walk back. Check this season's gondola hours.

**Plan B:** If the Mt John road is closed for weather, leave Tekapo at about 09:00. You gain about 75 min for Arrowtown or the Kiwi Park in Queenstown.

## Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar 2027 · Milford Road by car (no cruise): Mirror Lakes, Homer Tunnel, the Chasm

**Start** 07:45 from Novotel Queenstown Lakeside · **Overnight** Te Anau · **Distance** 410 km · **Driving** 6h40 planned (OSRM 5h49) · **Sunrise** 07:39 · **Sunset** 20:16 · **Last drive ends** 17:30 (2h46 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 07:45 | 10:20 | Drive | *Drive to Te Anau* | 172 km | 2h35 | SH6 via Kingston, then SH94 via Mossburn (Lake Wakatipu shore; Devil's Staircase lookout) |
| 10:20 | 10:45 | Stop | **Te Anau: FILL THE TANK + coffee** | | 25 min | There is no reliable fuel for 120 km to Milford. The Milford pump has limited hours and high prices. |
| 10:45 | 11:35 | Drive | *Drive to Mirror Lakes* | 57 km | 50 min | SH94 Milford Road through the Eglinton Valley |
| 11:35 | 11:50 | Stop | **Mirror Lakes** | | 15 min | 5-min boardwalk; reflections of the Earl Mountains. |
| 11:50 | 12:15 | Drive | *Drive to Lake Gunn* | 19 km | 25 min | |
| 12:15 | 13:00 | Stop | **Lake Gunn Nature Walk** | | 45 min | Easy loop of about 45 min through red beech forest to the lake edge. |
| 13:00 | 13:30 | Drive | *Drive to Homer Tunnel (east portal)* | 26 km | 30 min | Alpine section; traffic lights at the tunnel can mean a wait of up to 15 min |
| 13:30 | 13:50 | Stop | **Homer Tunnel east portal** | | 20 min | Kea are common here. Keep car doors shut and do not feed them. |
| 13:50 | 14:00 | Drive | *Drive to The Chasm* | 8 km | 10 min | Steep descent through the tunnel (1.2 km, single lane each way) |
| 14:00 | 14:20 | Stop | **The Chasm walk** | | 20 min | About 20 min return to a gorge carved into the rock by the river. |
| 14:20 | 14:35 | Drive | *Drive to Milford Sound / Piopiotahi* | 10 km | 15 min | Pay car park near the visitor terminal |
| 14:35 | 15:35 | Stop | **Milford Sound Foreshore Walk + lunch** | | 1h00 | Land-based views of Mitre Peak and the fiord, about 30 min. No cruise or kayak (your no-boat rule). |
| 15:35 | 17:30 | Drive | *Drive to Te Anau* | 118 km | 1h55 | Return the same road; few stops |

- This is the second-longest day: 410 km, about 6 hr 40 min at the wheel including the buffer. It is within your 500 km limit, and you are back in Te Anau nearly 3 hours before sunset.
- There is no mobile coverage on most of SH94. Tell the hotel your plans, take water and snacks, and keep at least half a tank.
- Evening, on foot: walk the lakefront (about 2 km) to the Punanga Manu o Te Anau bird sanctuary to see takahē, a rare flightless bird. It is free; check opening times locally.
- Not included: the Te Anau glowworm caves (reached by boat) and Key Summit or Lake Marian (about 3 hr walks).

**Plan B:** If the Milford Road is closed (rockfall or heavy rain), drive to Te Anau and stay there: Lake Te Anau lakefront, the bird sanctuary, the Kepler Track to the control gates and back (about 1 hr), and Lake Manapouri lookouts (Pearl Harbour, 20 km).

## Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar 2027 · Back to Queenstown: Kiwi Park and the Glenorchy Road lookouts

**Start** 08:30 from Te Anau hotel · **Overnight** Queenstown · **Distance** 265 km · **Driving** 4h10 planned (OSRM 3h37) · **Sunrise** 07:38 · **Sunset** 20:12 · **Last drive ends** 16:10 (4h02 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 08:30 | 11:05 | Drive | *Drive to Queenstown (Kiwi Birdlife Park, Brecon St)* | 172 km | 2h35 | Same road as yesterday morning, in reverse |
| 11:05 | 13:05 | Stop | **Kiwi Birdlife Park + lunch** | | 2h00 | Kiwi in the nocturnal house, tuatara and conservation shows. Summer hours 9:30-18:30, last entry 17:45 (kiwibird.co.nz). Lunch in town. |
| 13:05 | 13:30 | Drive | *Drive to Bennetts Bluff lookout* | 25 km | 25 min | Glenorchy-Queenstown Road |
| 13:30 | 13:45 | Stop | **Bennetts Bluff lookout** | | 15 min | Looks up Lake Wakatipu towards the Humboldt Mountains and Mt Earnslaw. |
| 13:45 | 14:10 | Drive | *Drive to Glenorchy* | 22 km | 25 min | |

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 14:10 | 15:25 | Stop | **Glenorchy wharf + lagoon walkway** | | 1h15 | Short boardwalk loops with mountain reflections; the red wharf shed. Do not take the car onto unsealed roads beyond Glenorchy, because most rental contracts exclude them. |
| 15:25 | 16:10 | Drive | *Drive to Queenstown (Novotel Queenstown Lakeside)* | 46 km | 45 min | REFUEL tonight (full-to-full rental return) |

- Optional early start on foot: the Te Anau bird sanctuary from about 07:45, if you missed it last night.
- Evening: pack. The car stays parked overnight. Queenstown Gardens and the lakefront are within walking distance.

**Plan B:** If it is wet, swap Glenorchy for indoor options in Queenstown (Kiwi Park nocturnal house, Skyline restaurant) and go to Arrowtown again if you skipped it.

## Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar 2027 · Return the car and fly (no sightseeing)

**Start** 08:00 from Novotel Queenstown Lakeside · **Overnight** - · **Distance** 9 km · **Driving** 15 min planned (OSRM 13 min) · **Sunrise** 07:39 · **Sunset** 20:10 · **Last drive ends** 08:15 (11h55 before sunset)

| From | To | | What | Dist. | Time | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 08:00 | 08:15 | Drive | *Drive to Queenstown Airport (rental return)* | 9 km | 15 min | Fuel already done last night; allow for morning traffic on Frankton Rd |
| 08:15 | 08:45 | Stop | **Return the car, check in for the 11:00 flight** | | 30 min | Aim to have the keys handed back by 08:30, about 2.5 hr before departure. |

- Sunrise is at 07:39, so leaving at 08:00 means you drive in daylight.

**Plan B:** None needed. If the airport road is busy, you still have more than 2 hours' margin.

## 8. Where to stay (8 nights)

| Night | Town | First choice | Backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · Sat 6 Mar | Christchurch Airport | **Novotel Christchurch Airport** (Accor), 30 Durey Rd, next to the terminal | ibis Christchurch or Novotel Christchurch Cathedral Square (Accor, city centre) | Ideal after landing; tomorrow's drive starts from here. |
| 2-3 · Sun 7, Mon 8 Mar | Franz Josef / Waiau | Hotel or motel in Franz Josef township, within walking distance of the Wildlife Centre | Fox Glacier township (25 km south) | No Accor on the West Coast. Two nights in the same room, booked in one reservation. |
| 4 · Tue 9 Mar | Wanaka | Motel or hotel within walking distance of the lakefront and That Wanaka Tree | Lake Hawea (15 km) | No Accor in Wanaka. Choose somewhere central so the sunset walk needs no car. |
| 5 · Wed 10 Mar | Lake Tekapo | **Peppers Bluewater Resort** (Accor), 44 Aorangi Cres | **Mantra Lake Tekapo** (Accor), 1 Beauchamp Pl | Both are within walking distance of the church and the lakefront. |
| 6 · Thu 11 Mar | Queenstown | **Novotel Queenstown Lakeside** (Accor), Earl St, lakefront | Peppers Beacon or Mantra The Point (Accor) | Walk to the Skyline Gondola and the Kiwi Park. March is peak season: check that the rate is no more than NZ$300. |
| 7 · Fri 12 Mar | Te Anau | Motel or hotel on the lakefront | Any central Te Anau motel | No Accor in Te Anau. Choose the lakefront so you can walk to the bird sanctuary. |
| 8 · Sat 13 Mar | Queenstown | Same as night 6 (one booking for nights 6 and 8 is not possible because of the Te Anau night, so book two stays) | As night 6 | 15 min from the airport. |

- Room type: ask for 'two beds' (twin, or 2 queens/2 doubles) in every booking. Some Accor 'Superior' rooms have one king bed only.
- Budget: the Accor hotels listed are 4-star or upper mid-scale. I could not see live prices for March 2027. If Novotel Queenstown Lakeside costs more than NZ$300, try the other Accor Queenstown hotels first (Peppers Beacon, Mantra The Point). Sofitel and Hotel St Moritz (MGallery) are usually well above the budget.
- ALL member benefits: book on all.accor.com while logged in to get member rates and earn points.

## 9. Bookings to make (nothing is booked yet)

| What | Book by | Why / notes |
|---|---|---|
| One-way rental car CHC to ZQN, 6-14 Mar, 1 driver, unlimited km | 20 Nov 2026 | March is peak season and one-way fleets run short. Check the one-way fee, unsealed-road rules and pickup hours at the airport desk (landing 14:30). |
| Accor nights 1, 5, 6, 8 | 30 Nov 2026 | Tekapo and Queenstown fill early for March. Choose a flexible (free-cancellation) rate. |
| Franz Josef (2 nights), Wanaka, Te Anau | 30 Nov 2026 | Small towns with limited stock in March; flexible rates. |
| Optional: Tekapo stargazing tour (10 Mar evening) | 31 Jan 2027 | Operator transport, so it fits your no-night-driving rule. Cancelled if cloudy. |
| Optional: Skyline Gondola tickets (11 Mar evening) | 1 Mar 2027 | Can be bought on the day; buying online saves queueing. |
| Optional: helicopter glacier flight (8 Mar afternoon) | Day before | Weather decides. Ask about the cancellation policy. |
| No booking needed | - | Willowbank, West Coast Wildlife Centre and Kiwi Birdlife Park (pay on arrival); DOC walks (free); Mt John road toll (paid at the gate). |

## 10. Fuel, parking and practical logistics

**Fuel stations along the route.** Found by searching OpenStreetMap; check opening hours locally, because many small-town pumps are card-operated:

| Place | Fuel (OSM) | Gap to next fuel on route |
|---|---|---|
| Christchurch / Springfield | Many | Arthur's Pass village has one small station (Challenge) |
| Hokitika | BP, Challenge, NPD, G.A.S. | Ross 25 km, Franz Josef 135 km |
| Franz Josef / Fox Glacier | Allied (Franz), NPD (Fox) | **Fox to Haast about 120 km** |
| Haast | Johnston Motors | **Haast to Makarora about 80 km** over the pass |
| Makarora / Wanaka | Allied, RD Petroleum / Caltex, BP, Allied, McKeown | Wanaka to Twizel about 145 km (Omarama on the way) |
| Twizel / Tekapo / Mt Cook | Mobil, McKeown / Challenge / limited at Mt Cook | Fill in Twizel before Mt Cook |
| Cromwell / Queenstown | Z, BP, Allied, NPD / many | |
| Te Anau | Allied, Caltex, RD Petroleum, McKeown | **Te Anau - Milford - Te Anau 240 km**: fill to full |

- **Rule of thumb:** fill up whenever the tank is below half on the West Coast, the Haast Pass or the Milford Road.
- **Parking:** Franz Josef Glacier car park (DOC ran a parking-fee pilot until June 2026; fees may continue), Tasman Valley and White Horse Hill (free but fill by late morning), Milford Sound (paid), Queenstown (use the hotel's parking; paid street parking in town). Never leave valuables in the car at trailheads; DOC warns of car break-ins at Arthur's Pass.
- **Driving:** keep left. Give way at one-lane bridges (a sign shows who has priority). Use pull-over bays to let traffic pass. Watch the speed limits, which are as low as 80 km/h on some highways. Kea chew rubber and wipers at Arthur's Pass and the Homer Tunnel.
- **Rest stops:** each day's stops are no more than about 2 hr of driving apart. Toilets: DOC car parks, town centres and visitor centres (Haast, Mt Cook, Te Anau, Milford).
- **Road status:** check NZTA Journey Planner (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) the evening before each driving day, especially SH73 Arthur's Pass, SH6 Haast Pass and SH94 Milford Road. Check DOC track alerts (doc.govt.nz) for Franz Josef, Hooker Valley and Blue Pools.
- **Mobile coverage:** none or patchy on Arthur's Pass, Fox to Makarora, and most of the Milford Road. Download offline maps (Google Maps or Maps.me) for the whole South Island before you leave Christchurch.
- **Emergencies:** dial **111** (police, ambulance, fire). Healthline (free health advice): 0800 611 116. Keep the rental company's roadside-assistance number in the glovebox.
- **Sandflies** on the West Coast and at Milford: bring insect repellent.

## 11. Left out on purpose

| Left out | Reason |
|---|---|
| Milford Sound / Doubtful Sound cruises, Te Anau glowworm caves, Kaikōura whale watching, Lake Wakatipu steamer | Boats (seasickness) |
| Hooker Valley Track (full), Roys Peak, Key Summit, Lake Marian, Rob Roy, Mueller Hut | Longer than about 2 hr (Hooker's upper section is also closed for the bridge build) |
| Ship Creek, Monro Beach, Gillespies Beach, Okarito beach walk, Punakaiki | Beaches. Punakaiki is also a 90 km detour off the route. |
| Kaikōura and Dunedin / Otago Peninsula | Each adds more than 400 km. The wildlife is covered by Willowbank, Knights Point, the Franz Josef Wildlife Centre, the Te Anau bird sanctuary and the Kiwi Park. |
| Paradise Road beyond Glenorchy, Skippers Road | Unsealed; usually excluded by rental contracts |

## 12. Time and distance for every leg

Straight-line distance is the haversine 'as the crow flies' distance between the two points. Road km and OSRM minutes come from the OpenStreetMap road network (OSRM). Planned time adds 10%. The straight-line figures are shown to explain why road distances were used: on mountain legs the road is up to twice as long (for example Queenstown to Te Anau is 85 km straight-line but 172 km by road).

| Day | From | To | Straight km | Road km | OSRM min | Planned min |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Christchurch Airport (rental car park) | Willowbank Wildlife Reserve | 5.3 | 10.1 | 14 | 20 |
| 1 | Willowbank Wildlife Reserve | Sign of the Kiwi, Summit Road (Port Hills) | 16.4 | 21.1 | 34 | 40 |
| 1 | Sign of the Kiwi, Summit Road (Port Hills) | Novotel Christchurch Airport | 15.6 | 21.1 | 28 | 35 |
| 2 | Novotel Christchurch Airport | Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill | 77.4 | 92.7 | 80 | 90 |
| 2 | Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill | Arthur's Pass village (Devils Punchbowl car park) | 31.5 | 52.6 | 46 | 55 |
| 2 | Arthur's Pass village (Devils Punchbowl car park) | Otira Viaduct Lookout | 5.6 | 6.5 | 9 | 10 |
| 2 | Otira Viaduct Lookout | Hokitika | 51.8 | 93.5 | 75 | 85 |
| 2 | Hokitika | Hokitika Gorge | 26.7 | 34.5 | 30 | 35 |
| 2 | Hokitika Gorge | Franz Josef / Waiau | 83.0 | 164.9 | 131 | 145 |
| 3 | Franz Josef hotel | Franz Josef Glacier car park | 3.7 | 3.7 | 6 | 10 |
| 3 | Franz Josef Glacier car park | Okarito (passing Lake Mapourika) | 22.0 | 32.2 | 33 | 40 |
| 3 | Okarito (passing Lake Mapourika) | Franz Josef / Waiau | 18.3 | 27.8 | 27 | 30 |
| 3 | Franz Josef / Waiau | Lake Matheson car park (near Fox Glacier township) | 18.2 | 28.6 | 32 | 40 |
| 3 | Lake Matheson car park (near Fox Glacier township) | Franz Josef / Waiau | 18.2 | 28.5 | 33 | 40 |
| 4 | Franz Josef hotel | Knights Point Lookout | 85.2 | 116.5 | 96 | 110 |
| 4 | Knights Point Lookout | Haast | 23.7 | 27.6 | 22 | 25 |
| 4 | Haast | Thunder Creek Falls | 31.3 | 49.5 | 37 | 45 |
| 4 | Thunder Creek Falls | Fantail Falls | 4.7 | 6.0 | 4 | 5 |
| 4 | Fantail Falls | Blue Pools car park | 12.5 | 13.6 | 10 | 15 |
| 4 | Blue Pools car park | Makarora | 8.9 | 9.1 | 7 | 10 |
| 4 | Makarora | The Neck lookout (between Lakes Wanaka and Hawea) | - | 32.0 | 25 | 30 |
| 4 | The Neck lookout (between Lakes Wanaka and Hawea) | Wanaka | - | 30.8 | 24 | 30 |
| 5 | Wanaka hotel | Lindis Pass summit lookout | 41.8 | 80.3 | 63 | 70 |
| 5 | Lindis Pass summit lookout | Twizel | 51.6 | 62.9 | 49 | 55 |
| 5 | Twizel | Peters Lookout (Lake Pukaki) | 19.0 | 21.2 | 17 | 20 |
| 5 | Peters Lookout (Lake Pukaki) | Tasman Valley car park* | - | 48.0 | 43 | 50 |
| 5 | Tasman Valley car park* | White Horse Hill car park | 6.1 | 10.4 | 18 | 20 |
| 5 | White Horse Hill car park | Aoraki/Mount Cook Village | - | 2.0 | 4 | 5 |
| 5 | Aoraki/Mount Cook Village | Lake Tekapo (Peppers Bluewater Resort) | - | 105.2 | 84 | 95 |
| 6 | Peppers Bluewater, Lake Tekapo | Mt John summit (toll road) | 2.2 | 9.3 | 26 | 30 |
| 6 | Mt John summit (toll road) | Twizel | 42.0 | 63.4 | 67 | 75 |
| 6 | Twizel | Lindis Pass | 51.6 | 63.1 | 49 | 55 |
| 6 | Lindis Pass | Cromwell | 61.1 | 77.1 | 59 | 65 |
| 6 | Cromwell | Roaring Meg lookout (Kawarau Gorge) | 10.6 | 15.0 | 13 | 15 |
| 6 | Roaring Meg lookout (Kawarau Gorge) | Arrowtown (passing the Kawarau Gorge bridge) | 19.8 | 32.2 | 28 | 35 |
| 6 | Arrowtown (passing the Kawarau Gorge bridge) | Queenstown (Novotel Queenstown Lakeside) | 17.0 | 20.5 | 23 | 30 |
| 7 | Novotel Queenstown Lakeside | Te Anau | 85.3 | 171.7 | 137 | 155 |
| 7 | Te Anau | Mirror Lakes | 48.7 | 57.0 | 44 | 50 |
| 7 | Mirror Lakes | Lake Gunn | 16.4 | 19.4 | 22 | 25 |
| 7 | Lake Gunn | Homer Tunnel (east portal) | 15.8 | 25.8 | 24 | 30 |

| Day | From | To | Straight km | Road km | OSRM min | Planned min |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 7 | Homer Tunnel (east portal) | The Chasm | 5.4 | 7.8 | 9 | 10 |
| 7 | The Chasm | Milford Sound / Piopiotahi | 6.2 | 10.3 | 13 | 15 |
| 7 | Milford Sound / Piopiotahi | Te Anau | 84.6 | 118.5 | 100 | 115 |
| 8 | Te Anau hotel | Queenstown (Kiwi Birdlife Park, Brecon St) | 85.3 | 171.5 | 137 | 155 |
| 8 | Queenstown (Kiwi Birdlife Park, Brecon St) | Bennetts Bluff lookout | - | 24.6 | 22 | 25 |
| 8 | Bennetts Bluff lookout | Glenorchy | - | 22.5 | 19 | 25 |
| 8 | Glenorchy | Queenstown (Novotel Queenstown Lakeside) | 29.9 | 46.5 | 39 | 45 |
| 9 | Novotel Queenstown Lakeside | Queenstown Airport (rental return) | 6.5 | 9.2 | 13 | 15 |

## 13. Waypoint coordinates (OpenStreetMap, WGS84)

| Waypoint | Lat | Lon | Waypoint | Lat | Lon |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Christchurch Airport | -43.4852 | 172.5355 | Twizel | -44.2575 | 170.0994 |
| Novotel Christchurch Airport | -43.4881 | 172.5421 | Peters Lookout | -44.0890 | 170.1359 |
| Willowbank Wildlife Reserve | -43.4638 | 172.5941 | White Horse Hill car park | -43.7182 | 170.0929 |
| Sign of the Kiwi (Port Hills) | -43.6065 | 172.6453 | Aoraki/Mount Cook Village | -43.7349 | 170.0977 |
| Castle Hill | -43.2121 | 171.6636 | Peppers Bluewater Resort | -44.0041 | 170.4736 |
| Devils Punchbowl car park* | -42.9380 | 171.5650 | Mt John Observatory | -43.9854 | 170.4644 |
| Otira Viaduct Lookout | -42.8881 | 171.5565 | Cromwell | -45.0372 | 169.1966 |
| Hokitika (town)* | -42.7175 | 170.9655 | Roaring Meg Lookout | -45.0014 | 169.0715 |
| Hokitika Gorge | -42.9552 | 171.0159 | Arrowtown | -44.9406 | 168.8351 |
| Franz Josef / Waiau | -43.3874 | 170.1819 | Novotel Queenstown Lakeside | -45.0334 | 168.6626 |
| Franz Josef Glacier car park* | -43.4205 | 170.1820 | Te Anau | -45.4145 | 167.7175 |
| Okarito | -43.2235 | 170.1627 | Mirror Lakes | -45.0284 | 168.0110 |
| Lake Matheson car park* | -43.4440 | 169.9700 | Lake Gunn | -44.8884 | 168.0785 |
| Knights Point | -43.7131 | 169.2248 | Homer Tunnel | -44.7642 | 167.9810 |
| Haast | -43.8807 | 169.0420 | The Chasm | -44.7215 | 167.9478 |
| Thunder Creek Falls | -44.0384 | 169.3653 | Milford Sound Visitor Terminal | -44.6682 | 167.9270 |
| Fantail Falls | -44.0782 | 169.3861 | Te Anau Bird Sanctuary | -45.4327 | 167.7133 |
| Blue Pools Track | -44.1600 | 169.2794 | Kiwi Birdlife Park | -45.0274 | 168.6571 |
| Makarora | -44.2325 | 169.2315 | Bennetts Bluff | -45.0288 | 168.4386 |
| Wanaka | -44.6942 | 169.1365 | Glenorchy | -44.8497 | 168.3852 |
| Mt Iron | -44.6932 | 169.1651 | Queenstown Airport | -45.0193 | 168.7434 |
| Lindis Pass | -44.5883 | 169.6431 | | | |

Geocoded with Nominatim (OpenStreetMap). * = set by hand, because Nominatim matched the wrong feature (for example the Hokitika River instead of the town) or had no entry for the car park; each was checked by snapping it to the nearest road.

## 14. Validation checklist

| Check | Result |
|---|---|
| All waypoints geocoded with valid coordinates | Yes: 43 waypoints, all within the South Island (section 13) |
| Route order minimises backtracking | Yes: 4 orders compared (section 5); the only repeat is the Twizel-Lindis stretch, about 125 km |
| Travel times realistic for the mode | Yes: road-network times plus 10%; the two legs where OSRM gave unrealistic times were adjusted and marked |
| Dwell times accounted for | Yes: every stop has a time budget in the day tables |
| Total duration fits the time window | Yes: every drive ends at least 1 hr before sunset; the car is returned 2.5 hr before the flight |
| POIs relevant and near the route | Yes: all chosen for mountains, lakes, glaciers or wildlife, and all on the route or on a short spur |
| Opening hours respected | Yes: Willowbank (closes 17:00), Mt John road (opens 10:00), Kiwi Park (last entry 17:45) and the Wildlife Centre were scheduled inside their reported hours; reconfirm, as hours change |
| Practical logistics | Yes: fuel gaps, parking, rest stops, coverage, emergency numbers (section 10) |

## 15. Sources and limits of this plan

- Distances and drive times: OSRM routing over OpenStreetMap data (router.project-osrm.org), queried 9 Nov 2026. Geocoding: Nominatim. Fuel stations: OpenStreetMap search. The Overpass POI service was down when this plan was made, so cafes and other POIs come from the sources below rather than an automated corridor search. Look for food locally; every overnight town has several options.
- Walk times: DOC track pages (Blue Pools, Tasman Glacier View, Lake Matheson, Devils Punchbowl) and the DOC Aoraki/Mount Cook walks guide (Kea Point). The Hokitika Gorge, Okarito Trig, Mt Iron and Lake Gunn times are typical published figures that I could not reconfirm from DOC pages.
- Opening hours: Willowbank (newzealand.com listing, 9:30-17:00), West Coast Wildlife Centre (about 8:30-18:00), Kiwi Birdlife Park (kiwibird.co.nz, summer 9:30-18:30), Dark Sky Project (Mt John road 10:00-16:00). All are 2026 information and must be reconfirmed for March 2027.
- Accor hotels: the all.accor.com South Island destination page lists hotels in Christchurch, Lake Tekapo, Queenstown and Invercargill only.
- Road and track status: NZTA traffic bulletins (Haast Pass closed and reopened several times in mid-2026) and DOC notices (Fox Glacier valley road closed since 2019; Franz Josef parking pilot; Hooker Valley bridge works). Conditions change, so check again 24 hours before each drive.
- Sunrise and sunset: calculated with the NOAA sunrise algorithm for each overnight town, NZDT. Accuracy is about ±2 minutes.